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Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS / AI**

UNDER SCRUTINY

Major offshore betting platforms facing enforcement action in India

MAHADEV ONLINE BOOK

Offshore base
Dubai, UAE

Model
Sports betting and other wagers through franchised online panels

Up to
₹94,400 CR.
*Alleged revenue generated over 10 years, as per ED submissions**

PARIMATCH

Offshore base
Cyprus

Model
Online sports betting, promoted through sports sponsorships and surrogate brands

₹3,000 CR.
Alleged proceeds generated from Indian users in a year, as per ED

1XBET

Offshore base
Cyprus and Curaçao

Model
Online sports betting, including live betting, promoted through surrogate brands

₹1,000 CR.
Betting-related transactions identified in the ED investigation

**including by alleged associate brands, such as Gold365, Laser247, Tiger Exchange and SkyExchange*

Note: Figures reflect estimates reported in ED investigations. Asset attachments are provisional, subject to confirmation by the adjudicating authority, while prosecution complaints contain allegations yet to be tried in court

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Until a few years ago, Saurabh Chandrakar was selling fruit juice from a modest shop in Bhilai, Chhattisgarh. Today, he stands accused of masterminding Mahadev Online Book, an illegal betting empire that, at its peak, was alleged to have a daily turnover of Rs 240 crore-plus. From his base in Dubai, the 31-year-old had allegedly built a transnational operation that took bets from millions of Indians and generated fortunes for its promoters. This June, however, his luck ran out when, according to Indian investigators, he was arrested in Muscat, Oman, for allegedly entering the country on a forged passport. His arrest has given India a potentially crucial breakthrough in what appears to be one of the country's biggest online betting scandals.

Chandrakar's spectacular rise from obscurity might have gone unnoticed had he not displayed his newfound wealth with extraordinary flamboyance. In February 2023, he reportedly spent around Rs 200 crore on his lavish wedding in the United Arab Emirates, flying in kin and guests on chartered aircraft and hiring Bollywood stars to perform at the celebrations. The extravagance became a major lead for investigators probing suspicious financial transactions. As the Enforcement Directorate (ED) followed the money, it uncovered what it alleged was a sprawling betting syndicate operating through hundreds of local panels across India, with the proceeds funnelled through thousands of bank accounts, hawala operators and overseas entities.